An external auditor needs to:

a) Evaluate the organization's approach to identifying critical areas as well as other parameters.

For example, has the organization identified:
- its processes that are critical to product quality,
- its complex processes, or those that need special attention
- its processes that need to be validated
- its processes that need personnel to be qualified
- its processes that need close monitoring of process parameters
- its monitoring and measuring activities that require frequent calibration or verification.
- its activities and processes that occur across multiple locations or which are
- labor intensive, etc.
- processes where problems have occurred or are in risk, and
- established process performance indicators that define effectiveness and efficiency measures, and do these measures align with the organization's overall goals and objectives? Does the organization use such information when establishing the audit frequency of such processes and activities?

b) Evaluate the competence of the organization's internal auditors and audit teams.

There should be evidence that the organization:
- has identified the competence requirements for its internal auditors,
- engages auditors with the appropriate training,
- has in place a process for monitoring performance if its internal auditors and audit teams,
- includes personnel on its audit teams that have appropriate sector specific knowledge (so that they can identify where the likelihood that a deviation in a process or activity could lead to a significant consequence for product quality) An analysis should also be made of whether the internal auditors understand the inherent risk to the reliance that can be placed on the outcome of the audit process, if they:

- fail to consider something which is material to the outcome of the audit,
- select an inappropriate sampling regime,
- weight the evidence collected inappropriately, or
- deviate from the audit plan and internal audit procedures.

c) Evaluate the planning of audits.

The organization should be able to maximize the use of available resources during the conduct of internal audit activities. This can be facilitated by the adoption of a risk-based approach to the planning of internal audits. The results of this risk-based approach will enable the organization to define the audit program, the frequency, duration, and scope of internal audits, as 9001 does not specify these criteria. It should be ascertained whether the organization, through its internal audit process, has considered the use of a risk-based approach in developing the internal audit plan, to ensure the effective and efficient use of resources. This should also ensure that the inherent risks of audit failure in the audit process, and audit outcomes, are minimized.

The organization should have a process for utilizing past audit results in the planning of future internal audits.

d) Look for evidence that the organization has implemented an effective internal audit program.

By taking the above factors into account, and by examining whether the internal audit process is leading to any tangible improvements to the QMS, the third party auditor should be able to form a judgment on whether the organization has implemented an effective internal audit program and if the outcome of internal audits provides evidence for analysis of the effectiveness of the QMS. It is a good practice in third party audits to audit internal audits processes of the organization toward the end of the third-party audit. Auditors will be able to compare the results of internal audit process against their own findings and thereby be able to evaluate effectiveness of this process and the resulting corrective actions.